

Split Personality IIGS

The Apple IIGS is, uniquely, designed to run both IIGS Desktop programs *and* older Apple II-compatible (8-bit) programs. It's possible to run both a friendly Desktop program like the Finder *and* an older program with no user interface to speak of *on the same machine!* The authors of this older Apple software had to design and program their own user interfaces because Apple II models before the IIGS didn't have built-in support for the Apple Desktop. The result: no two programs ever worked the same way. (The consistency factor, remember?)

Some newer programs for 8-bit computers (Apple IIe and IIc) *do* use the Apple Desktop user interface. The designers of these programs took it upon themselves to make their programs work like the Apple Desktop, even though it meant programming a complete user interface. Although *Publish It! 4* and *ProTERM 3.0* (to name two examples) run on the IIGS as well as older Apples, and although they *work* somewhat like Desktop programs, *they're not IIGS Desktop programs.*

When you're using any 8-bit program on your IIGS, your IIGS is essentially pretending to be a IIe, and most of the special features of the IIGS are not available. You won't have access to System 6 features like New Desk Accessories (NDAs), File System Translators (FSTs), and IIGS printer drivers because, in its IIe emulation mode, the IIGS cannot support these features. That's not to say these look-alike programs aren't useful—many are. Just keep in mind that most of System 6's features work only from *real* Desktop programs.

▲ By The Way...

If there's a rainbow-colored Apple at the left end of the menu bar, you're probably using a real Desktop program. If there's no Apple or if the Apple isn't rainbow-colored, you're probably using a program that only looks like a Desktop program.

A Closer Look

Let's take a look at a screen from a IIGS Desktop program (Figure 3A). This screen happens to be from the Finder, but other Desktop programs have a similar look and feel. (The Finder is a bit unusual because it is specifically designed not for a particular application like word processing, but rather as an organizational tool for your disks, documents, and programs. Still, it's a program you'll be using frequently, so it's a good place to start.)

You'll first notice the menu bar at the top of the screen. The menu bar is the Desktop's "main menu." In non-Desktop programs, you're usually presented with a main menu containing general things you can do, which branches out into submenus. For example, in AppleWorks, when you select "Add Files To Desktop" from the main menu, you're presented with a submenu that allows you to create a new file or load an existing file to the Desktop.